

1989 General election: National Front forms minority government with support of nationalist BJP. The C(I) Party is implicated in the Bofors corruption scandal as Rajiv Gandhi and others are accused of receiving kickbacks from a defense contractor.

1990 Peacekeeping force is withdrawn from Sri Lanka. BJP leader Lal Advani is arrested for inciting intercommunal violence. Muslim separatist groups begin a campaign of violence in Kashmir. Congress (I) returns to power in coalition with JD.

1991 Congress (I) withdraws from government. Rajiv Gandhi is assassinated during the ensuing election campaign by a suicide bomber connected to Sri Lankan Tamil Tigers; Narasimha Rao becomes prime minister of a Congress (I) minority government. A program of economic liberalization is initiated.

1992 Hindu extremists demolish Babri Masjid mosque at Ayodhya, triggering widespread Hindu–Muslim violence; 1,200 people die.

1993 Resurgence of Hindu–Muslim riots. Bomb explosions in Mumbai.

1994 Rupee is made fully convertible. C(I) is routed in key state elections amid allegations of corruption. Talks with China are held in New Delhi aimed at reducing tensions at the border.

1995 Punjab chief minister is assassinated by Sikh extremists.

1996 Corruption scandal triggers political crisis. Hindu nationalist BJP is the largest party but fails to win vote of confidence; leftist United Front coalition government takes office.

1997 United Front government falls as C(I) withdraws support.

1998 General election; BJP led by Atal Bihari Vajpayee forms coalition

government. Sonia Gandhi, widow of Rajiv Gandhi, becomes president of C(I). India detonates a nuclear bomb to widespread international condemnation.

1999 India and Pakistan test nuclear missiles and clash violently in Kashmir. BJP returned to power in elections triggered by a vote of no confidence. A cyclone kills about 10,000 in eastern state of Orissa.

2000 Population reaches one billion. US President Bill Clinton makes historic visit.

2001 Earthquake kills more than 25,000 people in Gujarat. BJP government implicated in major bribery scandal connected to illegal arms sales. Kashmiri militants mount an armed attack on the parliament in Delhi. India launches satellite into space.

2002 Indian government accuses Pakistan of direct responsibility for terrorist attacks by Kashmiri separatists. Bloody inter-religious rioting breaks out in Gujarat. About 1,000 are killed. India test-fires a nuclear-capable missile.

2003 India and Pakistan declare a ceasefire in Kashmir. Direct air links between the two countries resume.

2004 Surprise victory for Congress Party in general elections. Manmohan Singh is sworn in as prime minister.

2005 Monsoon rains in Mumbai kill more than 1,000. First bus service in 60 years operates between India and Pakistan. An earthquake in Kashmir kills more than 1,000. Kashmiri rebels detonate bombs in Delhi, killing 62.

2006 Attacks by Islamic militants intensify, including over 180 killed by bombs on rush-hour trains in Mumbai.

2007 India and Pakistan sign agreement to reduce risk of accidental nuclear war.

2007 Pratibha Patil becomes India's first female president.

2008 Nearly 200 people are killed in attacks by militant gunmen in Mumbai.

2009 The Congress Party wins increased number of seats in the general election, but falls just short of an absolute majority.

«58–59 Mysteries of the Indus
«124–25 India's First Empire
«180–81 The Delhi Sultanate
«244–45 The Great Mughals
«352–53 The British Raj
«408–09 Mahatma Gandhi
«410–11 The Partition of India

Nepal



A Himalayan kingdom with an agricultural economy and a turbulent political history.

1769 Formation of the Nepali state by King Prithvinarayan Shah, Raja of Gorkha, following his conquest of three Nepal Valley kingdoms.

1814–16 Anglo-Nepalese war ends in a treaty that establishes Nepal's boundaries and recognizes its autonomy.

1816 Establishment of quasi-British protectorate ruled by hereditary Ranas.

1923 Treaty with Britain recognizes Nepali independence.

1951 End of Rana rule. Sovereignty of crown is restored; Nepalese Congress Party (NCP) forms the government.

1959 First multi-party constitution.

1960 Constitution is suspended by King Mahendra, who seizes political control.

1962–90 Under the panchayat nonparty system, the king exercises sole power.

1972 Birendra succeeds to the throne.

1980 Panchayat system confirmed by referendum.

1985 NCP begins a campaign of civil disobedience to campaign for the restoration of the multi-party system.

1990 Prodemocracy protests are violently suppressed. King Birendra agrees to a new democratic constitution.

1994 Minority communist government.

1995–98 Weak coalition governments. Maoist insurrection breaks out seeking the overthrow of the monarchy.

1999 NCP election victory. Maoist insurgency continues in rural areas.

2001 Royal family massacred in palace shootings by Crown Prince Dipendra. Gyanendra is crowned amid unrest.

2003 Rebels implement ceasefire, but pull out of peace talks with government.

2005 King Gyanendra dismisses prime minister and assumes direct power.

2006 Parliament reinstated by king following weeks of strikes and protests. Parliament curtails king's powers and holds peace talks with rebels.

2007 Maoists sit in parliament under the terms of a temporary constitution.

2007 Parliament approves the abolition of the monarchy.

2008 Former Maoists emerge as the largest party after parliamentary elections. Nepal becomes a republic. The Maoist leader Prachanda forms a government.

2009 Maoists leave the government in an argument over army reforms.

Bhutan



A forested Himalayan kingdom isolated from the outside world for most of its history.

1616 Unification of the state by Prince-Abbot Shabdrung Ngawang Namgyal.

1731 Tibet imposes suzerainty on Bhutan and this is passed on in turn to China.

1770s–80s UK involvement in Bhutan begins with missions sent by Warren Hastings after conflict between Bhutan and Cooch Bihar.

1864 Border war with the UK leaves Bhutan with loss of territory.

1907 Monarchy established. Ugyen Wangchuck is chosen as hereditary ruler.

1949 India is given influence over Bhutan's foreign affairs.

1952 National Assembly inaugurated.

1968 King forms first cabinet.

1971 Joins UN.

1972 King Jigme Wangchuk begins policy of modernization.

1990 Ethnic Nepalese launch campaign for civil rights. Thousands flee to Nepal.

1998 King proposes to reform government and cedes some powers.

1999 First TV service inaugurated.

2003 Bhutanese soldiers fight Indian separatist rebels.

2007 Agreement with India gives Bhutan more influence over foreign policy.

2008 The royalist Bhutan Harmony Party wins all but three seats in the country's first parliamentary elections.

«184–85 The Silk Road

INDIAN STATESWOMAN (1917–84)

INDIRA GANDHI

Prime minister of India from 1966–77, and again from 1980 until her assassination in 1984, Indira Gandhi was the daughter of India's first prime minister, Jawaharlal Nehru, and the mother of another, Rajiv Gandhi. She was elected to parliament in 1964.

In office, Gandhi began an ambitious program of modernization but in 1975 was convicted of electoral offenses relating to the 1971 election. She responded by clamping down on her opposition and the conviction was later overturned. She lost the 1977 election and was out of office until reelected in 1980. In 1984 she used the military to suppress Sikh rebels; a few months later, Gandhi was murdered by her Sikh bodyguards.

